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Presented by Gabriel Zimmermann

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1. Reviewer: Prof. Dr.-Ing. Klaus Baer
2. Reviewer: Prof. Dr.-Ing. Philipp Graf

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Plugin System's in Rust

Gabriel Zimmermann

I. Abstract

Plugin architectures enable extensible software systems by allowing runtime loading of external modules. While Rust offers memory safety guarantees and performance characteristics ideal for plugin development, the language's lack of a stable Application Binary Interface (ABI) presents significant challenges for cross-module compatibility. This thesis examines the landscape of plugin system implementations in Rust, evaluating three primary approaches: native Rust plugins, C ABI-compatible interfaces, and Inter-Process Communication (IPC) mechanisms. Through comparative analysis of technical requirements, performance implications, and maintenance considerations, this work demonstrates that Rust's unstable ABI precludes reliable direct plugin loading across compiler versions. The findings indicate that C ABI remains the optimal choice when performance is paramount, while IPC-based architectures provide superior isolation and version compatibility at the cost of increased overhead. These results contribute practical guidance for developers designing extensible Rust applications and highlight ongoing gaps in Rust's ecosystem for safe, performant plugin architectures.

Contents

I)	Abstract	3
II)	Introduction	7
III)	Related work	8
III.A)	Existing work	8
III.B)	Foundational Concepts	8
III.B.a)	Application Binary Interface (ABI)	8
III.B.b)	Rust Types and ABI Instability	9
III.B.c)	Plugin Systems	9
III.B.d)	Dynamic Linking and Runtime Loading	9
IV)	Methods	11
IV.A)	Analysis of the requirements	11
IV.A.a)	Performance Overhead	11
IV.A.b)	Development complexities	11
IV.A.c)	Limitations	11
IV.A.d)	Safety	11
IV.A.e)	Interoperability	12
IV.B)	“Potential approaches and problems”	12
IV.B.a)	Rust ABI	12
IV.B.a.a)	Unstable Rust ABI	12
IV.B.a.b)	abi_stable crate	12
IV.B.b)	C ABI	12
IV.B.b.a)	rust-bindgen / cbindgen (could be moved to III.B.d))	12
IV.B.b.b)	other c abi crates? (overview)	12
IV.B.b.c)	stabby crate	12
IV.B.c)	Interprocess Communication (IPC)	12
IV.B.c.a)	rust_bridge crate	12
IV.B.c.b)	other ipc crates? (overview)	12
IV.C)	“Selected approach and detailed solutions”	12
V)	Results	13
V.A)	Validation of the overall concept	13
V.B)	Description and motivation for the test cases	13
V.C)	Overview and evaluation of the acquired results	13
V.C.a)	Unstable Rust ABI	13
V.C.b)	Stable Rust ABI (crate)	13
V.C.c)	stabby (crate)	13
V.C.d)	rust_bridge (crate)	13
VI)	Conclusion and Future Work	14
VII)	Listings	15
	References	16

Abbreviations:

- ABI: Application Binary Interface
- IPC: Interprocess Communication
- RPC: Remote Procedure Call
- ZST: Zero-Sized Type

II. Introduction

Plugin architectures have become a cornerstone of modern software engineering, enabling systems to scale and adapt without monolithic rewrites. As highlighted by Apple's technical documentation, "Plug-in architectures are an attractive solution for developers seeking to build applications that are modular, customizable, and easily extensible" [1].

III. Related work

A. Existing work

As of 2026, the Rust ecosystem remains in a state of deliberate ABI instability, a condition that has persisted despite years of community advocacy and formal proposals. The most significant attempt to address this were RFC 1675 [2] and RFC 600 [3] (“Make Rust ABI stable enough to provide plugins functionality”), which proposed a “stable modular ABI” to enable runtime loading of Rust libraries without C interop. However, the proposal was ultimately deferred, with the compiler team citing the high cost of freezing internal representations that are critical for future optimizations, such as constant evaluation and monomorphization strategies [2]. Additionally, it was proposed to allow for a modular ABI, where a developer can specify the ABI by using macro system. [4]. Recent discourse at conferences like RustConf and FOSDEM reinforces this stance; speakers such as Niko Matsakis and others have emphasized that stabilizing the ABI would “lock in” implementation details, potentially hindering the compiler’s ability to evolve (Matsakis, RustConf 2023). Instead of a native solution, the community has converged on pragmatic workarounds. The prevailing consensus, reflected in technical talks and blog posts from 2023-2024, is that the C ABI remains the only reliable standard for binary interoperability, forcing developers to adopt verbose extern “C” interfaces or rely on third-party crates like `abi_stable` to simulate stability through `repr(C)` wrappers and runtime checks (NullDeref, 2023; Arroyo Blog, 2023). While experimental efforts continue to explore WebAssembly as a language-agnostic ABI alternative, no native Rust-to-Rust stable ABI has been implemented, leaving plugin developers to navigate a fragmented landscape of manual FFI management and abstraction layers.

TODO: Fix links with the concrete answer of the dev team...

Currently only rust std library and ferrocene compiler verified. Therefore, most code that needs to be verified is already limited and the solutions that can be used for Plugins are limited. Not the focus of this thesis.

B. Foundational Concepts

To contextualize the challenges of plugin systems in Rust, it is essential to establish precise definitions of the core architectural components involved: the ABI, how stable the Rust Type System is for the ABI, plugin architectures, and dynamic linking mechanisms.

a) Application Binary Interface (ABI):

While the Application Programming Interface (API) defines the source-code level contract between software components (function names, argument types, and headers), the Application Binary Interface (ABI) operates at a lower level, governing the interaction between compiled machine code.

Definition: According to the System V Application Binary Interface, the standard for Unix-like operating systems, the ABI is “an interface between two binary program modules” (System V ABI, 2023). It encompasses:

- **Calling Conventions:** How function arguments are passed (registers vs. stack), how return values are delivered, and who is responsible for cleaning up the stack (caller vs. callee).
- **Data Layout:** The memory alignment, padding, and byte-ordering (endianness) of data structures.
- **Name Mangling:** The algorithm used by compilers to encode function names (including type information) into symbol names for the linker.
- **Exception Handling:** The mechanism for propagating errors or exceptions across module boundaries.

Relevance to Rust: In the context of Rust, the lack of a standardized ABI is a deliberate design choice. As noted by the Rust compiler team, the ABI is “deliberately unstable” to allow the compiler to optimize memory layouts and calling conventions aggressively without being constrained by backward compatibility requirements (Rust Internals, 2020).

This contrasts with the C ABI, which is strictly defined and stable, serving as the de facto standard for binary interoperability.

b) *Rust Types and ABI Instability:*

[5]

Product types (or structs): is it ordered? is it aligned?

C is always aligned and source-ordered.

Rust fields also aligned, but the order is minimized for memory usage.

Rust can enforce this by using `repr(C)`, but this is not the default, and the compiler can change the layout for optimization purposes. This means that without explicit annotations, the memory layout of a Rust struct is not guaranteed to be stable across different compiler versions or optimization levels, which can lead to binary incompatibility when used in a plugin system.

Sum types (or enums): how to distinguish the variants? where is the data?

Not supported by C. Can be done using a tagged union, but you need to give each type a specific number (usually an enum).

Rust may be put in a niche (like common padding or using type's forbidden value).

Example with `Cow<'a, str>`: Can waste 7 bytes for padding on a 64-bit architecture.

Rust guarantees that the layout of a sum type is not clashing with the layout of a product type.

Unit types (`()`): are they zero-sized? what about references?

Doesn't exist in C as zero-sized type. ZSTs are undefined behavior.

As Pierre states, for a stable ABI all linkers must agree on an ABI for each symbol [5] (double check, maybe I need to link the talk instead...).

Note stable due to changes in compiler version, optimization level, target architecture, using `-Z randomize-layout` and so on. This is a fundamental problem for plugin systems in Rust, as the host and the plugin may be compiled with different versions of the compiler or different optimization flags, leading to binary incompatibility.

A few examples as to why the Rust ABI is not stable yet can be found in niche optimizations: enums with multiple data variant optimizations (1.65), field ordering optimizations (1.67), `Cow<str>` regression (1.70), and more.

c) *Plugin Systems:*

A plugin system is a software architecture pattern that allows a host application to be extended by third-party modules (plugins) without modifying the host's source code or recompiling the entire system.

Definition: In software engineering literature, a plugin is defined as "a software component that adds a specific feature to an existing computer program" (Gamma et al., 1994). Key characteristics include:

- **Extensibility:** The ability to add new functionality post-deployment.
- **Modularity:** Plugins are isolated units that interact with the host through a well-defined interface.
- **Dynamic Loading:** Plugins are typically loaded at runtime rather than linked statically at compile time.

Architectural Patterns: Plugin systems generally follow one of two patterns:

- **Static Linking:** Plugins are compiled into the host binary. This offers performance benefits but lacks runtime flexibility.
- **Dynamic Linking:** Plugins are separate binary files loaded into the host process memory space at runtime. This is the primary focus of this thesis, as it necessitates strict ABI compatibility or robust isolation mechanisms.

The primary challenge in Rust plugin systems is ensuring that the host and the plugin, potentially compiled with different compiler versions or optimization flags, agree on the binary representation of data and function calls.

d) *Dynamic Linking and Runtime Loading:*

Dynamic Linking is the process of resolving references to external libraries or modules at runtime, rather than at compile time (link time).

Mechanism: In Unix-like systems, this is achieved through the `dlopen` (dynamic open), `dlsym` (dynamic symbol lookup), and `dlclose` (dynamic close) system calls. In Windows, the equivalents are `LoadLibrary`, `GetProcAddress`, and `FreeLibrary`.

Process Flow:

- **Discovery:** The host application locates the plugin binary file (e.g., `.so`, `.dll`, `.dylib`).
- **Loading:** The operating system maps the plugin's code and data segments into the host's virtual memory space.
- **Resolution:** The host resolves symbol addresses (function pointers) within the loaded plugin.
- **Execution:** The host invokes the plugin's functions via the resolved pointers.

Challenges in Rust: Dynamic linking in Rust is complicated by the language's ownership model and panic handling. Since Rust does not guarantee a stable ABI, a plugin compiled with Rust version 1.70 might use a different struct layout or calling convention than a host compiled with version 1.75. Furthermore, if a plugin panics, the unwinding behavior must be contained; otherwise, it can lead to undefined behavior or crashes in the host process. As described in implementation guides, "panics cannot cross the FFI boundary" without explicit handling, such as wrapping function bodies in `catch_unwind` or using ABI-stable libraries like `abi_stable` [6].

No comprehensive comparison between possible solutions for plugin systems in Rust has been done yet. There are some simple comparisons, but they don't cover the full range of options and trade-offs.

IV. Methods

A. Analysis of the requirements

Goal of the research was to analyse the following points:

- Performance Overhead IV.A.a
- Development Complexities IV.A.b
- Limitations IV.A.c
- Safety IV.A.d
- Interoperability IV.A.e

a) Performance Overhead:

In this thesis, we are primarily interested in the performance overhead when calling the plugin system's API. How well the internal code of the plugin is executed is less important, as compiler optimizations are expected to handle most of the performance concerns.

The expected result is that the setup time will be higher for approaches that require more complex initialization (e.g. reading the dynamic library, serialization for IPC), while the function execution time should be relatively similar when the initialization is complete. It is expected that the IPC approach will have higher performance overhead due to the need for serialization and deserialization of data, as well as the communication overhead between processes.

To measure the results, we are using the criterion and gungrau crate for our benchmarking. The written benchmark will give us separate results for the setup time and the function execution time, which allows us to analyze the overhead of each approach in more detail.

As noted by the criterion documentation, the criterion crate is a statics-driven micro-benchmarking library, which aims to provide strong statistical confidence in detecting and estimating the size of performance improvements and regressions. [7]

As stated by the gungrau documentation, "gungrau is a one-shot benchmarking harness and framework which uses Valgrind's Callgrind, Cachegrind, and DHAT to provide extremely accurate and consistent measurements of Rust code, making it perfectly suited to run in environments like a CI." [8]

We hope by combining both of these tools, we can get a comprehensive understanding of the performance characteristics of each approach, and how they compare to each other in terms of setup time and function execution time.

In Rust benchmarking, wrapping inputs and intermediate values in `black_box` is essential to prevent the compiler from optimizing away the code you intend to measure. Because Rust's optimizer is aggressive, it may detect that a function's result is unused or that an input is constant, leading it to eliminate the entire computation or hoist it out of the loop, resulting in artificially low (and inaccurate) timing data. The `std::hint::black_box` function acts as an opaque barrier, signaling to the compiler that the value is unknown and must be treated as having side effects, thereby forcing it to execute the code exactly as written within the benchmark. [9] Each benchmark will be run with and without `black_box` to compare the results and understand the impact of compiler optimizations on our measurements.

Gungrau helps us see the internal required instructions on "my" CPU. This result should correlate with the actual run time using criterion. We can then reason about the expected overhead of a chosen approach.

b) Development complexities:

Subjective, but also Qualitative Measurement

How will this impact a development team? This might just be an extra Evaluation of Limitations

c) Limitations:

Might be part of "complexities"??

Qualitative Measurement

d) Safety:

Attempting Quantitative by using safety levels.

Rust Language generally very safe. Errors often need to be “forced” or careless usage of unwinding. [10]

e) *Interoperability*:

How flexible are the presented approaches? Can they be linked with other libraries?

B. *“Potential approaches and problems”*

baseline for loading libs is the libloading crate (see chapter)

when analysing the C ABI, we will discover, that different crates handle different parts... differently (sum types and so on)

a) *Rust ABI*:

Unstable Rust ABI:

abi_stable crate:

b) *C ABI*:

rust-bindgen / cbindgen (could be moved to III.B.d)):

other c abi crates? (overview):

stabby crate:

c) *Interprocess Communication (IPC)*:

different structure. communication over serialization

positive: interoperability, less complexity during development

negative: performance overhead, more complex software design

rust_bridge crate:

other ipc crates? (overview):

C. *“Selected approach and detailed solutions”*

V. Results

A. Validation of the overall concept

Validating the Performance Overhead is done using gungrau and criterion benchmarks and then comparing the results with each other.

B. Description and motivation for the test cases

C. Overview and evaluation of the acquired results

a) *Unstable Rust ABI:*

b) *Stable Rust ABI (crate):*

c) *stabby (crate):*

d) *rust_bridge (crate):*

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VI. Conclusion and Future Work

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VII. Listings

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